Talks at GS

Managing the World's Largest Publicly Traded Hedge Fund: Man Group CEO Robyn Grew

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Robyn Grew: I'm quite interested in people who have a desire to try and tackle tricky questions and ideally with lots of other people around them. I quite like that. I like the people who come to the table and are willing to ask the stupid question, which is never ever stupid. Or the people who come to you and go, "I've had this crazy idea."

Introduction: Welcome back to Talks at GS, where we speak with pioneering leaders about their careers and the future of their fields. In a live conversation, Goldman Sachs's John Storey joined Robyn Grew, CEO of Man Group. This session was recorded on October 2nd, 2025, at Goldman Sachs headquarters in New York City. Let's listen in now.

John Storey: Welcome to another session of Talks at GS. I'm John Storey. I'm global co-head of equity distribution and also co-head of One Goldman Sachs. I'm delighted to be joined by Robyn Grew, the CEO of Man Group, a global

alternative investment management firm with 193 billion of AUM. I've known you for quite some time.

Robyn Grew: Yeah.

John Storey: I know you as someone with incredibly infectious energy and a massive desire to compete.

Robyn Grew: Yeah, a little bit.

John Storey: So why don't we start initially with unpacking you. What are the salient points of your life, your upbringing that have shaped the person that you are now?

Robyn Grew: I am a great example of, if you have children and they aren't terribly focused on academia and maybe they act out a little bit and perhaps they're a little bit strident about lots of different things that they're socially driven by and maybe they don't always listen to your advice and they get terrible haircuts and terrible friends, terrible, awful, friends you really don't want them to have, turns out you can be all right.

It's very hard for my parents to get over this still. And in fact, I've spent the last probably decade of my life saying, "No, no, really. No, people do take me seriously." They're like, "How?"

So what are the salient features? I think a bit of that. I think a bit of going through life and not being that textbook type person actually stood me in great stead for some of the things I've done later in life. And I slightly worry about the -- well, of course I would because I'm this -- but the person who goes through life very easily for me, the straight A's person who goes to all the right schools and goes to all the right colleges --

John Storey: That was not me, by the way.

Robyn Grew: I know that. I have some of the photos. I don't but see me afterwards.

If you're that and then you hit failure at 24, 25, 27, whatever it may -- and that's the first time ever, holy moly, that's a shocker. For me, not so much of a shocker. So there you go. So the salient parts of that are you can do great things and you don't have to be perfect, I think. And

I hope I've still got stuff to do.

John Storey: Okay, let's jump to Man Group. Also a fascinating origin, which is so unique to the United Kingdom.

Robyn Grew: Isn't it?

John Storey: Yeah.

Robyn Grew: Yeah.

John Storey: For those of you who don't know, it started off in 1783 --

Robyn Grew: Yeah.

John Storey: -- as a barrel maker.

Robyn Grew: That's right.

John Storey: I'll elaborate on that in a second. And has since evolved into the firm it is today. So as I said before, you merge around 193 billion in AUM. To put that in

context, that was around 79 billion ten years ago. Since you took the helm, assets under management have grown by 15%-ish. So talk us through the evolution of the firm and what it looks like now, how you describe the business today.

Robyn Grew: Yeah, when you say, "Hey, listen, the firm was established in 1783," let me put that into context. That was before --

John Storey: Put that in context of when Australia was found.

Robyn Grew: That's exactly right. Put that in the context of when the French Revolution was. It was before then. But it's that sense of, you know, Man Group made barrels and actually had the monopoly of rum ration supplying to the Royal Navy. That's what the firm did. And from that came commodity trading. And that's how you start it.

Well, hang on a second, how did you get from that? Well, you need commodities to make rum and you need sugar, so think about it like that. So it's an extraordinary example of making sure that you're always relevant and that you're

evolving for the needs of what you need to do and what clients want.

We are a good example of what it is to innovate. If we were still making barrels on the side of the River Thames, we may not be in business today. But that's the point about Man Group.

So where does it go? So it's commodities background. You've got a fundamentally extraordinary CTA business in our quant capability. That's where it kind of comes from, that CTA capability. Probably the most cutting edge. Certainly first adopter, first capabilities in this space. And it's grown. And it's grown into being more than just a systematic trading on CTA and the macro side.

We have a micro quant capability that has been part. We're also a firm built of acquisitions. We can talk about that if you want. We've also got a discretion or a fundamental arm as well. And so from barrels on the side of the River Thames, we're now a very, very sophisticated quant investor, discretionary investor, solution provider to some of the largest allocators in the world.

You have to be incredibly disciplined -- and I think this is across all of our businesses -- in pretty much anything you do. You have to know what you're trying to get to. You have to understand what the tenets of what you're trying to achieve.

So for us, we want orthogonal. Such a quant word. We need uncorrelated content. We want something we don't do, something we can scale, something we know our clients want, something that we believe has a cracking management team, and guess what? A next-generation underneath it. Something where the alignment of the business itself works with us, that we can put it to work. Something where the price point is right and that the payout structure is right.

So how do you ensure that you have alignment, that you're not just paying somebody to get very, very wealthy and then they might not stick around for some time? How do you do that?

Now, when you put all of those things together, it can all be brilliant. But the real thing that matters is culture. If you can't culturally connect, it won't work. And so we have

gotten to terms, we've gotten to financial numbers, we've done all sorts of wonderful things, and walked away from deals where we just don't think culturally we can make it work. And that discipline has held us in good stead.

Now, it doesn't mean it has to be the same. Like, if you talk to a quant and you talk to a discretionary investment manager, they're quite different. I mean, it's a very basic way of framing it, but it's absolutely so that we're not looking for people to be the same. But they've just got to be culturally aligned because that's how we deliver the best results for our clients.

John Storey: Well said.

Robyn Grew: There you go.

John Storey: Well said. Okay, you've been at the firm for 15 years-plus now. When you took over from Luke Ellis, the previous CEO, in September of '23, you already knew the firm intimately. You knew Luke very, very well, and it's not very different from when you come from the outside. So September. You get the job. What's the first thing that runs through your mind as what you need to put your

footprint on the firm as the new CEO?

Robyn Grew: So the first thing, the first thing was, one, you're right, I'd been there for some time and I'd been part of the senior management team for some time, so it would have been quite peculiar if I'd decided that everything that we'd done was entirely wrong. So that would have been odd.

So the first thing that went through my mind was reassuring people that I wasn't going to break what we had. It's really easy sometimes to get ahead of yourself in these things and forget that what you have already is pretty special. And actually people need quite a lot of reassurance that you're not going to break it because people want to put your footprint on things, like you just said, John.

You know, there's maybe a little bit of an impetus to say I need to mark, I need to mark this. And so number one was let's not break it, and let's make sure I communicate that very loud and clear, both internally and externally. What we have is a tremendous business. I think we can take it on its next journey, but I'm only going to do that if I don't

break this thing. So number one, don't break it.

Number two, the ambition of Man is -- of the Man Group -- and maybe it should be "man" more generally, "hu-man." So the ambition is that we stay relevant, that thing that we talked about right at the beginning. That we are here to do a really good job in really difficult times with the biggest allocators in the world who are entrusted with -- let us not forget this -- the hard-earned savings and pensions of real people who've worked really hard all of theirs lives and they rely on all of us to make sure that they have financial security in their future retirements or their futures.

We don't cure cancer. I wish I was smart enough to do that. But what we do provide is financial security and stability, and that enables people to access health care, education, pay the bills, it's a roof over people's heads. It's something that's incredibly important to people all over the world. And so our job, to turn up every day, is to ensure that we do that and we do that to the very best of our abilities. And we do that with people who need our help.

So what do we do? So when I walk in and we carry on this journey, I was very keen to focus resources on how we

could increase content. How do you provide more product, more opportunity for clients to think about you in a way that solves more of the challenges they face? How do I get to more people, because I reckon I've got good stuff? And if I can help more people, I would like to do that. And so that sort of bedded down into a few areas.

One credit. Massively important. A big area. Hadn't really been that important. I mean, when I was running around in investment banking, it was important then it wasn't important anymore because interest rates were zero and we were in this kind of benign environment. But it was becoming important again, and people need and want to think about credit, especially as a noncorrelated return stream. So credit was important to me.

More content for solutions. We're building and we have a capability that allows people to come to us and say, "Listen, I don't need that particular fund. I need that minus a bit of leverage or with a bit of vol plus a bit of an overlay, and can I throw this other thing into it as well?" And we call that our solutions business. And the more that you have an ability to fix a problem or a challenge that's the shape and size that your clients have, the more valuable you are to

them. So I wanted to do discretionary content as well so that we could enable that solutions-driven outcome.

And I wanted to build out our equity quant business. I wanted to grow that long-only, the long-short, the mid-frequency, the quant alpha capabilities. I wanted to grow that. I think there is enormous opportunity in that space.

And then if you partner that, you go, "Okay, so where else can I be useful?" Well, fastest growing segment in the world is wealth. How do I get more relevant? How do I push that forward? The deepest capital market in the world is the US. We're underweight there. Let's get our hands on some of that. And by the way, the more that you're doing credit and that capability, the more you can be relevant to insurance.

So those were sort of the tenets. Now, on top of that, how do you do it? You do it with talent and you do it with tech. And so the talent-technology piece is incredibly important to us. It is part of our DNA. Tech is part of who we are. We took second-most spoken or thought about language at Man Group: Python. You know, think about it like that. It's that intrinsic to who we are.

So those were the tenets, and then I did something that we had not done before at Man Group and I told everybody about it in the outside world and within the firm. And that was something that was different for us. We like to do things quietly, and it wasn't that we didn't have diversification or strategies or acquisitions or those sorts of things. We didn't go around telling people about this is what we're going to put our focus and our money behind, but this time we did.

John Storey: Very good. AI has been a big part of your firm for a long time, part of your DNA. How has AI and machine learning begun to alter your investment process?

Robyn Grew: That's a great question. So excited about AI. If you think I've been excited so far, you haven't seen anything yet.

You're right. It's absolutely. When we talk about AI, we probably talk about something we feel we've been engaged in for 15 years. Listen, Goldman Sachs, fabulous place, great partner of Man Group's, but we don't want to rely on your algos for our execution. We want to build our own, so

we did.

And it's that sort of capability that's been just inherently part of who we are. But the question around investment and how does it help us? Well, it helps us in a number of different fonts. We've had sort of three generations-ish. And these things all exist alongside one another.

We created ChatGPT, ManGPT. We created something called Alpha Assistant, which is something that I'll explain in a minute. And then we just most recently launched AlphaGPT. Now, we're not very exciting when it comes to the names, are we? That's what happens when you give people --

John Storey: You could be a little bit more exploring.

Robyn Grew: We could, couldn't we? Not so much. So that first version of the sort of the ChatGPT, that Man GPT piece, was that bit where you've got the most "write me a job description" type stuff, you know? That sort of piece. More robotics. More help you in workflows. More those types of bits.

When you think about Alpha Assistant, think about co-piloting. Thinking about something where you can leverage the tech to be faster, smarter, better you're still really in charge of it.

And then the latest version, which I'll talk a little bit more about, is this Alpha piece, which is much more agentic. The way I've described it really is it's sort of changing the verbs. Kind of. So you go, "Tell me," in the first couple of instances. "Tell me about this." Right? "Inform me."

And now we're into "build me." And it means that people like I -- you can mess with quants. Actually, I shouldn't really weaponize it like that, but I just have and it's been way too much fun not to in the last six weeks. So this means that what we've been able to do is we've crossed that extraordinary line where you think you can't possibly get inside a researcher's head, you can't really replicate that. Turns out you can do a little bit more than you thought you could with agentic.

Turns out that if you can treat neural networking in a sense and you have good datasets -- and we do because we have, as I mentioned, 35 years of curated data because we

are founded in quant -- you can start to create faster, smarter, and "build me" capabilities. So we now have life through the agentic capability. Life signals working. Now, fully, fully commissioned through our regular process of review by real people and smart technologies and smart quants. It hasn't just gone from black box into production, right? It's gone through the checks, balances, and that's incredibly important. But we now have the capability of being able to understand and create ideas with the value of this technology.

Now, I said this before and I'll say it out loud. I feel really quite good about that because I have 600 people who are really smart and who understand both the power of this technology but also understand its limitations and its risks. Technology is a fabulous thing. I think what it will do for us over the next 18 months, let alone the next five to ten years, is going to be phenomenal in the world more generally.

Neurosurgeons are now using much more capably-assisted computer-generated AI 3D imaging in order to undertake more complex operations. That's fantastic, right? Outcomes are better. Margins are better. Survival rates

are better. Capabilities are better. Things we couldn't get cured, think about before, we can now. All of that stuff.

You would not want me to be undertaking that operation, however good the capabilities around it. And if you did, I'm not going to tell you the disclaimer you'd have to sign. That's the power of some of this tooling and technology. So the fact that I have this in the hands of people much smarter than me -- much smarter -- is why I sleep at night.

John Storey: As the model's become a bit more ubiquitous, do you stress? Or how do you think about maintaining that competitive edge, finding that alpha?

Robyn Grew: I think the reality -- the hardest thing for all of us is to find alpha, and alpha degrades and becomes commoditized and becomes factor, right? We all know that. So the tech war, as it were, is a very, very real outcome. I think the reality of -- if you're scraping the entirety of the Web right now, good luck. Right? I think that part of the challenge is having the quality of the underlying data and the capability to understand whether that's good or not. I think it's the ability to scale it. I think it's the ability to portfolio optimize it. I think it's the ability

to execute. It's not just one thing. It's throughout your organization and throughout your capabilities that you're deploying the very best.

And so I don't worry so much about that. Let's do it a different way. Thirty-five years ago, you had a handful of markets and you could charge very healthy fees on that CTA product. You, all of you, could leave today and set up that right now. We are now 800 markets in, and it's the execution and the capability and the scale to do it at that level that keeps that product at the edge of where it is, but it's certainly not the fees it was.

And so it's that that you keep on innovating around. No model goes in and you don't have an innovation and a change process. Everything we do I can map where we have changed the models and where the delta is and what the outcome would have been had the models not changed. And we do that at every point in every part of our quant processes.

If ever you want a map of a product, you get that with quant in a way you can't get it with fundamental or discretionary management. Now, do discretionary

managers benefit from this touchingly? Every day of the week.

John Storey: Of course, yeah.

Robyn Grew: Every day of the week. And so you're providing, you're empowering every part of your organization, but it at the front end of the organization or all the way through. Three or four years ago, the area that most used robotics at Man Group was operations. So when you talk about the increase in AUM, we haven't increased our headcount in ops, but that was through tech. That's below the surface what you don't see that is the engine room of the organization. That's where it gets exciting.

John Storey: Let's talk about the change in competitive landscape because you've seen, since 2017, the rise of the multi-manager who have really grown at five times the growth of the industry. Performance has been pretty extraordinary. Quant, like yourselves, have posted I think double-digit returns pretty much since '21, so it's been quite an amazing period. Enormously competitive environment now for attracting talent, retaining talent. How do you think about that for your firm? And also the

changing dynamics of the markets given the new participants that are involved?

Robyn Grew: Yeah, listen, talent is tough. It's tough. And the multi-strats have taken -- so we have a multi-strat, we have a flagship multi-strat. Its performance is great. The talent piece has been the bit that you get across the press and you get everywhere else. Everyone else will talk about the $100 million check. Who doesn't?

How do we think about talent in that space? They're very different models. Like all hedge funds, not all multi-strats are created the same. They are structured very differently. Their talent is very different. The fund is very different. The payout levels can be very different. And I'm not going to name names, but you can guess them.

And so how do we fit into that? If you're not going to write a 50-buck check or a 100-buck check, does that mean you don't get great talent? And the answer is no. You get really good talent, but you're looking for a different type of talent. So how do we think about it?

We want, we will never set up people to compete with one

another within Man Group. Not interested in doing that. Right back to the acquisition story. We're very, very interested in uncorrelated content, but we want to take that and we want to build that. We don't want it to compete. It's hard enough competing on the street. We're not going to set that up within the firm.

Two, we want people who are going to build a business with us, who are going to recognize that their contribution is to real people and that I want to put their content to work within a number of different places. Maybe it's within a fund. Maybe it's not. Maybe it's from the strategy within a multi-strat. Maybe it's in part of our multi-strat program, maybe it's part of a different type of solution.

So people who want to build businesses want to do that over time, and they want to build legacy. And they're quite interested in getting capital from multiple, different places as opposed to one person. So we have capital from seed, we have capital from real third parties, we have capital from multi-strat or solutions capability. That's quite appealing if you want to build a business. And we do want to build people over time so that, when they create their legacy, when we tool them up with all of the things that

they want from a research or an analyst or a quant or a trading or an execution perspective, we've got all of that. And we have one of the best, if not the best, salesforce for the buy side. We have this extraordinary capability to talk to the very, very best allocators in the world.

And so if you care about those things and you care about how you can grow within that, we are not short of people wanting to work at Man Group. We turn down far more people than we hire, but we're on a BD of let's think about it in five to 17 a year we will add in, if I get my way.

John Storey: That's great. A lot of people have commented about you that you're a person who runs towards the fire. How do you look for that desire in the talent that you're looking to bring on board?

Robyn Grew: I think it's a curiousness, isn't it? I mean, why do people run towards fires? A bit of stupidity, yes. But also a bit of how do I get involved to solve that? I'm quite interested in people who have a desire to try and tackle tricky questions and ideally with lots of other people around them. I quite like that. I like the people who come to the table and are willing to ask the stupid question,

which is never ever stupid, or the people who come to you and go, "I've had this crazy idea." And actually most times it is in fact totally and utterly barmy. But occasionally it's brilliant. And so I look for that.

I'm slightly less excited by the people who are perfect, actually. I'm slightly more excited by the people who come with something else.

John Storey: Okay. You don't have to have a view on markets in the industry in which you excel, but I think this group would like to hear what is your view on markets given the extraordinary movements we've seen this year? Just once again, NASDAQ, S&P's at all-time highs.

Robyn Grew: I know. I mean, so what's my view? Well, I had this thing yesterday where somebody asked my views on markets, and I said, listen, what's kind of interesting about what's going on, particularly in the US right now, is I think we all thought that equities were priced to perfection about six months ago. And since which time they've just continued on this staggering journey of resilience. I mean, enviable resilience, I think you might say.

So I think we've got a situation where we've got definitely data to come. We have got challenging geopolitical issues which are impacting and influencing markets. We have volatility and dispersion which should mean we are needed more than we've been needed before. That it feels to me like US equities have got to have a little bit of a slowdown at some point. That credit is coming back. That private equity is still not equitizing. That allocators and large pools of money are looking for opportunity and others are looking to work out how do they get out of their illiquidity. That we are no longer in a space where the US leads everything. That the world is bifurcated, if not more than that, in its experience of recession, stagflation, or not. And therefore the opportunity set is huge for all of us to do the best jobs we can do.

John Storey: What a great place to finish. I started today talking about your infectious energy. I'm pretty sure the audience has felt like that. So on behalf of all of us at Goldman Sachs, Robyn, thank you so much for spending times with us today.

Robyn Grew: You're very welcome.

Conclusion: Thanks for joining us for another episode of Talks at GS, recorded on October 2nd, 2025. If you enjoyed the show, we hope you follow on your platform of choice and tune in for another episode.

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